

# FLAPPERS AND freedom

## THE ROARING TWENTIES



### ▲ Women about town

Women in the 1920s gained not only the right to vote, but also more freedom and independence. This British advertisement shows two wealthy women on a shopping spree.

In the aftermath of World War I, suffrage began to achieve its goals. Some women over 30 gained the vote in the UK in 1918, and in 1920, the 19th Amendment was ratified in the US, granting citizens voting rights regardless of their sex. However, it was increased financial freedom that would most transform women's lives in the 1920s.

### The rise of the flapper

The postwar economy of North America experienced a huge boom. The US transformed from a young industrial state to a world superpower with a large consumer economy. Women who had entered the workforce during the war now had access to disposable income of their own, and became a major consumer power able to make active buying choices. Inventions such as the vacuum cleaner and washing machine enabled many women to spend less time on domestic chores—in the 1920s, American women on average spent between 52 and 60 hours a week on housework—and increased leisure time.

Many young men had died during the war or from the 1918 Spanish flu epidemic. Rather than wait at home to be married, some women chose to celebrate their survival and freedom. Barriers that had been broken down during the war led these women to want to be treated as men had previously been—and allowed to do as they pleased. This new, liberated woman was known as a flapper—a woman who smoked, drank, drove a car, wore short skirts, and cut her hair in a bob. The androgynous look of flappers was influenced by French fashion, with such women being called *garçonne* (the feminine form of “boy”) in Paris. Tight corsets were abandoned in favor of more practical clothing, such as Coco Chanel's innovative women's suit and little black dress. Her clothes were revolutionary, with designs

